

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN ICELAND

Complete Community Opposition How-To

This guide is built around the fight for Þjórsárver — a highland wetland saved from the national power company after half a century of pressure — and it names the tools you'll meet (sustained opposition, the Ramsar and nature-reserve protections, the local referendum, the master-planning and appeal rights) in plain words. It is honest, too, about Kárahnjúkar, the dam that was lost.

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Deep in Iceland's central highlands lies **Þjórsárver** — a vast oasis of tundra, ponds, and marsh where roughly **a third of the world's pink-footed geese** come to breed, a **Ramsar wetland** and nature reserve set in Europe's largest remaining wilderness. For half a century the state utility, **Landsvirkjun**, pressed a scheme called **Norðlingaölduveita** to dam and divert the water there, flooding part of the wetland to feed the power grid. And for half a century Icelanders — scientists, conservationists, and ordinary citizens who love the highlands — pushed back, marshalling the science of the geese and the wetland, the Ramsar status, and sustained public opposition, until the scheme was defeated and the area protected. A wilderness that a national utility wanted for half a century was kept.

The Icelanders who saved Þjórsárver — scientists, conservationists, and citizens who love the highlands — held out for half a century, and a strong democracy gave them real tools to make that opposition count, where protest, petition, and litigation are lawful and safe. The **Ramsar and nature-reserve protections** guard wetlands and wilderness. The **national master plan for energy sites** — the *Rammaáætlun* — decides which projects may proceed and is a national arena you can shape. The **local referendum** is powerful on a community's own ground: the year after Þjórsárver, one in **Hafnarfjörður rejected a smelter expansion**. And the **participation, environmental-assessment, and appeal rights of a strong democracy** back it all. But these tools have real limits, and this guide is honest about the other half of the ledger. In the east of the country, the great **Kárahnjúkar dam was built**, over fierce and sustained opposition, flooding highland wilderness to power an aluminium smelter — a hard, painful loss; Icelanders do not always win these fights. The pressure to build hydro and geothermal power and heavy industry is strong and national, Kárahnjúkar shows that determined utilities and governments do sometimes win, and a highland scheme in a remote, thinly-peopled interior can be hard to rally a public around. So aim for what these levers can deliver by marshalling the science and the public and using every protection and appeal.

The Whole Strategy in One Idea

A hydro scheme or a smelter looks unstoppable when a national utility and the drive for power and industry are behind it, but it depends on protections, plans, permits, and public acceptance with weak points, and a chain breaks at its weakest link. An Icelandic fight turns on **sustained public opposition**; on the **Ramsar and nature-reserve protections**; on the **national energy master plan**; on the **local referendum**; and on **assessment and appeal rights**. Every one of those is a link you can grab — and sustained opposition, marshalling the science, is the one that saved Þjórsárver over half a century. **Find the one closest to your hand and pull.**

Be Honest About Which Fight You're In

Before you spend months — or years — on this, work out your real situation:

- **If it threatens a wetland or wilderness, marshal the science and the protections** — Þjórsárver's geese, its Ramsar status, and sustained opposition beat a fifty-year scheme.
- **If the project needs a place in the energy master plan, that's a national arena** — the *Rammaáætlun* decides which schemes may proceed.
- **If it's a local industrial project, a referendum can stop it** — Hafnarfjörður voted down a smelter expansion.
- **But know that these fights can be lost** — Kárahnjúkar was built over fierce opposition; the drive for power and industry is strong.

Read the whole guide once before you move. Two habits run through it: **marshal the science and sustain the public opposition that saved Þjórsárver**, and **use every protection, plan, vote, and appeal a strong democracy gives you** — while being clear-eyed that, as Kárahnjúkar shows, not every fight is won.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

To break the chain you have to see it — who decides, how a project moves, and where its weak points are.

Who Actually Decides

Big energy and industry involve the state utility **Landsvirkjun** and the national government, driven to build hydro, geothermal, and heavy industry. But the **national energy master plan** (*Rammaáætlun*) decides which schemes may proceed; **Ramsar and nature-reserve** status protects key places; **environmental assessment** and **planning** rules apply; **municipalities** and **local referendums** hold real power over local projects; and a strong democracy gives **participation and appeal rights**. And beneath it all, **sustained public opinion** — Icelanders' love of the highlands — can decide a fight, as it did at Þjórsárver. Know which of these lie between the project and the ground.

How a Project Moves — and Where You Jump In

The master plan. A scheme needs a place in the energy master plan. *Your opening:* argue it into the "protected" or "on hold" category, not the "use" one.

The protections. *Your opening:* the Ramsar status, the nature reserve, the wetland science, as at Þjórsárver.

The assessment and permits. *Your opening:* the environmental-assessment and planning process, with its participation and appeal rights.

The local vote. *Your opening:* a municipal decision or referendum, as at Hafnarfjörður.

The public. *Your opening:* the sustained public opposition that decides the hardest fights.

Follow the Money and the Permissions

Dig up three things. **What the project needs to proceed** — a place in the energy master plan, an assessment, permits, municipal approval — because each is a stage you can contest. **What it would harm** — the wetland, the wilderness, the geese, the highlands — the science that beat Þjórsárver. **Where the public and the local vote stand** — because sustained opposition and a local referendum are decisive

Icelandic levers.

Who's Supposed to Be Watching

Each is an ally or an arena. The **energy master-plan process** (*Rammaáætlun*) decides which schemes may proceed. The **Environment Agency** and **planning authorities** run assessment and permits. **Ramsar and nature-reserve** protections guard key places. **Municipalities** and **local referendums** hold local power. Iceland's **strong environmental groups and scientists** supply the evidence and the campaign. And the **Icelandic public**, with its deep love of the highlands, is the force that saved Þjórsárver.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Size up the odds honestly. These are rough patterns, not promises, in a strong democracy where the drive to build power and industry is nonetheless real. What most moves them: the strength of the science and the public opposition, and whether a protection, plan, or vote lies in the project's path.

What you do	Roughly works	How long	Cost	What "works" means
Just gather documents	5–10%	weeks	low	The base for everything else
Marshal the science (wetland, wildlife)	35–60%	months–yr	low	The case that beat Þjórsárver
Enforce Ramsar / nature-reserve status	35–60%	months–yr	low	A protected place kept protected
Shape the energy master plan (<i>Rammaáætlun</i>)	30–55%	1–3 yr	low	A scheme kept out of the "use" list
Environmental assessment + appeal	25–50%	1–2 yr	low–mod	A permit delayed or quashed
Local referendum / municipal decision	35–60%	months–yr	low	A local project voted down (Hafnarfjörður)
Sustained public opposition	40–65%	years	low	The decisive lever (Þjórsárver)
Everything together	45–70%	years	low–mod	A wilderness or wetland protected
Against a determined national push	20–45%	years	mod	Sometimes lost (Kárahnjúkar)

The levers that move the needle most are **sustained public opposition** and the **wetland-and-wildlife science**, backed by **Ramsar protection**, the **master plan**, and the **local referendum**. Þjórsárver shows the ceiling (a fifty-year scheme by the national utility defeated) and Kárahnjúkar the honest floor (a great dam built over fierce opposition). So aim for a wilderness protected, a Ramsar status enforced, a scheme kept out of the plan, or a local project voted down — by marshalling the science and the public.

On cost: Iceland's levers cost mainly organised effort and good science, not much money — the master-plan and assessment processes, the referendum, and the public campaign are open to citizens. The great strength is a strong democracy with real protections and a public that loves the highlands; the honest limit is that a determined national push for power and industry sometimes wins, as at Kárahnjúkar.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Being against "development" is weak. Being specific — this wetland, this master-plan category, this local vote — is strong. Answer five questions in writing.

1. What is it, and what does it need to proceed? Name the scheme (a hydro diversion, a dam, a smelter), the utility or company, and what it needs: a place in the energy master plan, an assessment, permits, municipal approval — each a stage you can contest.

2. What would it harm? The **wetland, the wilderness, the wildlife, the highlands** — marshal the **science**, as the geese and the wetland science beat Þjórsárver.

3. Is the place protected — or could it be? Whether it holds, or could gain, **Ramsar or nature-reserve** status, a decisive protection.

4. Is there a local vote or master-plan decision to win? A **municipal decision or referendum** (as at Hafnarfjörður), or a **master-plan categorisation** (*Rammaáætlun*) you can shape.

5. Where does the public stand? The strength of **public opposition** — the decisive Icelandic lever, which you can build.

What this looks like in real life. A national utility wants to dam and divert water in a highland wetland. The five questions yield: the scheme and its need for a master-plan place and permits (the stages to contest); the harm to the wetland and its geese (the science); the Ramsar and reserve status (the protection); the master-plan categorisation to win; and a public to rally. That's the Þjórsárver pattern — marshal the science, enforce the protections, shape the plan, and sustain the opposition.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

The difference between a campaign that saves a wilderness and one that doesn't is proof — the science that beat Þjórsárver. Build it in three layers.

Layer one: the science of the place. Document the **wetland, the wildlife, the wilderness** — the geese, the ponds and marshes, the highland ecology — because the science of a place like Þjórsárver is what defeats a scheme and enforces a Ramsar protection.

Layer two: the protections and the plan. Get the **Ramsar and nature-reserve** status, and the project's place in the **energy master plan** and the **assessment** — because these are the arenas where a scheme is stopped.

Layer three: the public and the local vote. Map where the **public and the municipality stand**, because sustained opposition and a local referendum are decisive. Walking to the master-plan process, the assessment, and the public with strong science and Ramsar status is what saved Þjórsárver.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

- **The science of the place** — the wetland, the wildlife, the wilderness, the geese.
- **The protections** — Ramsar status, nature-reserve designation.
- **The plan and permits** — the energy master plan (*Rammaáætlun*), the environmental assessment.
- **The local decision** — the municipal role, the possibility of a referendum.
- **The public** — where opinion stands, and how to build it.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Documents give you a case; sustained public opposition rooted in a love of the highlands gives you the power that saved Þjórsárver over half a century. Build in four moves.

Root it in the highlands and the wilderness. The Þjórsárver fight drew on Icelanders' deep attachment to their highlands and wildlife. Root the effort there, in the place and what it means, and marshal the science that gives that love its argument.

Bring in the scientists and environmental groups. Iceland's strong environmental organisations and its scientists supply the evidence — the wetland and wildlife science — that defeats a scheme and enforces a protection. Bring them in early.

Use the plan, the protections, and the local vote. Shape the **energy master plan**, enforce the **Ramsar and reserve** status, use the **assessment and appeal** rights, and — for a local project — pursue a **municipal decision or referendum**, as Hafnarfjörður did.

Build to last. Þjórsárver took half a century. Build clear roles, a good archive, ways to decide together, and the endurance to sustain opposition across the long timelines these fights can run — while accepting, as Kárahnjúkar teaches, that not every fight is won.

STEP 4: SCIENCE, PROTECTIONS, THE PLAN & THE VOTE

Iceland's levers combine the science of a place, its formal protections, the national plan, and the democratic vote.

Sustained Public Opposition and the Science

The Þjórsárver lever: **marshal the science** of a place — the wetland, the wildlife, the wilderness — and **sustain the public opposition** that a love of the highlands makes possible, over however long it takes. This combination beat a national utility's fifty-year scheme, and is Iceland's most powerful move.

The Ramsar Protections and the Energy Master Plan

Enforce **Ramsar and nature-reserve** status to guard a place, and shape the **national energy master plan** (*Rammaáætlun*) — which decides whether a scheme may proceed at all — to keep a project out of the "use" list and into "protected" or "on hold."

The Assessment, the Appeal, and the Local Referendum

Use the **environmental-assessment and planning** process, with its participation and appeal rights, to delay or quash a permit; and, for a local project, use a **municipal decision or referendum**, as Hafnarfjörður voted down a smelter.

The Honest Limits

Straight talk: these levers are strong, but the drive for power and heavy industry is national and real, and it sometimes wins — **Kárahnjúkar** was built over fierce opposition. A remote highland scheme can be hard to rally a public around. So use every lever — the science, the protections, the plan, the assessment, the vote — sustain the opposition, and count a wilderness protected, a Ramsar status enforced, a scheme kept out of the plan, or a local project voted down as wins, while knowing that not every fight is won.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

A stack of documents wins nothing until you aim it.

Wildlife becomes a reason to protect. Not "we love this place" but "*a third of the world's pink-footed geese breed here — a Ramsar wetland we cannot flood,*" as at Þjórsárver.

A protection becomes a barrier. "*This is a Ramsar site and a nature reserve — it must not be dammed.*"

The master plan becomes the decision point. "*This scheme belongs in the 'protected' category, not the 'use' one.*"

A local vote becomes a veto. "*Our municipality can, and should, vote this project down,*" as Hafnarfjörður did.

Match it to the venue: the wetland and wildlife science to the assessment and the master-plan process; the Ramsar status to the protection authorities; the local case to the municipality and a referendum; the wilderness and the geese to the public.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

In Iceland, the media front is about rallying a public that loves the highlands, because sustained public opposition is the decisive lever — it saved Þjórsárver.

Lead with the wilderness and the wildlife, not procedure. Not "the master-plan categorisation is disputed" but "they want to flood a highland wetland where a third of the world's pink-footed geese breed." Use your strongest material: the geese, the wetland, the wilderness, the highlands Icelanders love.

Work the public and the decision-makers. A rallied public shapes the master plan, the assessment, and the local vote. Make it easy: clear science, striking images of the highlands and wildlife, and a clear ask (protect it; keep it out of the plan; vote it down).

Two hard rules. Accuracy above all — in a science-literate country, one exaggeration can cost credibility. And offer the honest, positive vision: a wilderness kept, not just a project stopped — the vision that sustained the Þjórsárver fight for half a century.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Make them your own; keep them short, exact and calm; keep a copy of everything.

8A — To the energy master-plan process (*Rammaáætlun*).

Subject: [Scheme] belongs in the protected category.

"We submit that [scheme] at [place] should be placed in the 'protected'/'on hold' category, not 'use': [wetland, wildlife, wilderness reasons]. [Attach the science.]"

8B — Enforcing Ramsar / reserve status.

Subject: [Place] is a Ramsar site — protect it.

"We record that [place], a Ramsar wetland and nature reserve, would be harmed by [scheme]: [specifics]. We ask you to enforce its protection. [Attach evidence.]"

8C — To the Environment Agency / assessment.

Subject: Environmental assessment — [scheme].

"We submit evidence on [scheme]'s harm to [wetland/wildlife/wilderness]: [specifics], and ask that the assessment reflect it. [Attach science and contact.]"

8D — Appeal (to a lawyer / appeals body).

Subject: Appeal — [permit/decision].

"We seek to appeal [permit/decision] on [scheme]: [grounds]. We ask your advice. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8E — To the municipality / for a referendum.

Subject: A local vote on [scheme].

"We ask the municipality to [refuse / put to referendum] [scheme] at [place]: [specifics], as Hafnarfjörður voted down a smelter expansion. [Contact.]"

8F — To the utility / developer.

Subject: Opposition to [scheme] at [place].

"We are the community and citizens opposing [scheme], which would harm [wetland/wilderness]. We will use the master plan, the protections, the assessment, and — if local — a referendum. [Contact and evidence summary.]"

8G — Letter to the press.

Subject: They want to flood a highland wetland of global importance.

"[Scheme] would harm [Þjórsárver-like wetland / wilderness] where [a third of the world's pink-footed geese breed]. We can provide the science and the images. [Contact.]"

8H — Rallying the public.

Subject: Our highlands — let's keep them.

"[Scheme] threatens [our wilderness/wetland]. Þjórsárver was saved by sustained opposition, and Hafnarfjörður voted a smelter down. Let's do the same. [Contact.]"

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you must move fast and lean — though these fights can run long — do these six things, in order:

1. **Marshal the science of the place — the wetland, the wildlife, the wilderness.**
2. **Check and enforce its Ramsar / nature-reserve protection (8B).**
3. **Get it into the "protected" category of the energy master plan (8A).**

4. **Submit to the environmental assessment, and appeal if needed (8C/8D).**
5. **For a local project, push for a municipal decision or referendum (8E).**
6. **Rally the public that loves the highlands (8G/8H).**

Even lean, those six marshal the science and the public — the Þjórsárver template.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Iceland's field is mostly fair, but the drive for power and industry tilts it, so plan for it.

When a national utility and the drive to build push hard. Landsvirkjun pressed Þjórsárver for fifty years, and won Kárahnjúkar. Don't expect a quick win: marshal the science, enforce the protections, shape the master plan, and sustain the opposition for the long haul.

When the place is remote and the public is distant. A highland scheme in a thinly-peopled interior can be hard to rally a public around. Lean harder on the science, the Ramsar status, the master plan, and the assessment — and work to make the distant wilderness feel like everyone's.

When a fight is lost. Kárahnjúkar was built. Icelanders do not always win. Where a scheme proceeds, shift to minimising harm, holding conditions, and protecting the next place — and take the long view that Þjórsárver rewards.

When it's a local project. Use your strongest local lever: the **municipal decision or referendum**, as Hafnarfjörður did, backed by the assessment and the public.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO'S CAPTURED

Iceland is a strong, low-corruption democracy, so outright corruption is rare — but capture by the drive for power and heavy industry, and cosy ties between a state utility, government, and industry, can still tilt a decision, so stay alert.

How to spot it. A scheme pushed despite strong science against it; a master-plan categorisation that ignores the evidence; an assessment that reads as a formality; benefits to a utility or an industrial user while a wilderness bears the cost.

Who's supposed to guard against it. The **energy master-plan process**, the **Environment Agency** and **planning authorities**, the **courts and appeals bodies**, Iceland's **strong environmental groups and free press**, and the **public and municipalities** — all real and effective in a strong democracy.

How to fight it safely (and it is safe here). Document precisely and factually — the science ignored, the process shortcut, who benefits — and use Iceland's open, effective channels: the master-plan process, the assessment and appeal, the courts, the press, and the public. In a strong democracy, a well-evidenced, public case is powerful, and the referendum and master plan are yours to use.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Don't run these steps one after another — run them together. The science builds your case; the Ramsar status and the master plan protect the place; the assessment and appeal delay or quash the permit; the local referendum can veto a project; and sustained public opposition decides the hardest fights. Together they multiply. One at a time, they stall — and, as Kárahnjúkar shows, even together they can lose, so take

the long view.

Early on (year 1): marshal the science; check the Ramsar and reserve status; map the master-plan and assessment stages; begin building the public.

In the thick of it (years): shape the master plan; submit to and appeal the assessment; pursue a local referendum if apt; grow the public opposition.

The long haul (years — even decades): sustain the opposition, as Þjórsárver's defenders did for half a century; hold the line for a wilderness protected, a Ramsar status enforced, a scheme kept out of the plan, or a local project voted down.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Stopping a destructive project in Iceland can be done — a highland wetland where a third of the world's pink-footed geese breed was saved from the national power company after half a century of sustained opposition, and a community voted a smelter expansion down. Hold both truths. Iceland's distinctive power is real: sustained public opposition rooted in a deep love of the highlands, marshalling the science of a place, and using the Ramsar protections, the national energy master plan, the environmental assessment, and the local referendum, can defeat even a national utility's long-pressed scheme. And the constraints are real: the drive for power and heavy industry is national and strong, and it sometimes wins — the Kárahnjúkar dam was built over fierce opposition, a hard and honest loss — and a remote highland scheme can be difficult to rally a public around.

Here's the discipline that wins what can be won. Marshal the science of the place — the wetland, the wildlife, the wilderness — because that science, at Þjórsárver, defeated a fifty-year scheme. Check and enforce its Ramsar and nature-reserve protections. Shape the national energy master plan to keep the scheme out of the "use" list. Use the environmental assessment and its appeal rights, and — for a local project — pursue a municipal decision or referendum, as Hafnarfjörður did. And above all, sustain the public opposition that a love of the highlands makes possible, over however long it takes. Where a fight is lost, as Kárahnjúkar was, minimise the harm and protect the next place. Count a wilderness protected, a Ramsar status enforced, a scheme kept out of the plan, and a local project voted down as wins. That is how Þjórsárver was saved — the science and the public, over half a century, using every protection a strong democracy gives. So can you.